

6.1 What is the digital divide?

The **digital divide** refers to the differences in people's ability to access technology, such as smart phones, personal computers, tablets, laptops and TV, and the information and communications services they provide. A digital divide exists between those who have full access to technology and those that have restricted or no access. There can be a digital divide between countries, different **demographic** groups (particular sections of the population) and different **economic** areas (areas defined by their production and use of goods and services). The digital divide can be judged by several factors, such as a person's age, income and location.

The digital divide is a complex and growing issue. Information technology generally brings many benefits to people. For example, you can interact with your bank account from a smart phone. You can place orders for goods/shopping using a computer and the internet. You can access knowledge and learning from a wide range of places using the internet. A lack of access to technology is seen as a disadvantage. It may lead to inequality. People who are not able to access technology may miss out on opportunities, both in their personal lives and in the workplace.

For a country, the digital divide may describe the difference between those who have regular access to modern technology and those who do not. At an international level, a digital divide may describe the difference between countries with access to the latest technology and those countries that have less access to modern technology.

DISCUSSION POINT

What do you think are the main causes of digital divides in your country?

Understanding the digital divide matters because access to modern technology can bring many benefits to people and countries.

It is important to remember that digital technology also has challenges. Some people may choose to avoid modern technology because of these issues, for example some people might not trust the development of **artificial intelligence (AI)**. Other people might experience a negative effect on their health because of social media.



Figure 6.2: Some people might not have access to a computer, smart TV, mobile phone, or tablet.
